

ABOUT REEM ASSIL

Reem Assil is a Palestinian-Syrian chef and activist, based in Oakland, CA, working at the intersection of food, community, and social justice. She is the founder of nationally-acclaimed Reem's California, an Arab bakery and restaurant that builds community across cultures and experiences through the warmth of Arab bread and hospitality. Reem has garnered an array of top accolades in the culinary world, including James Beard finalist for Outstanding Chef (2022) back to back semifinalist for Best Chef: West (2018-19). Before dedicating herself to a culinary career, Reem spent over a decade as a community and labor organizer, building leadership to have a voice in their jobs and their neighborhoods. Reem is the author of IACP award-winning cookbook *Arabiyya: Recipes from the Life of an Arab in Diaspora* (2022).

ABOUT 18MR

Our Mission: Harnessing the power of the internet, cultural work, and movement building, 18MR grows Asian American political power by educating, mobilizing, and organizing Asian Americans towards taking collective action online and offline.

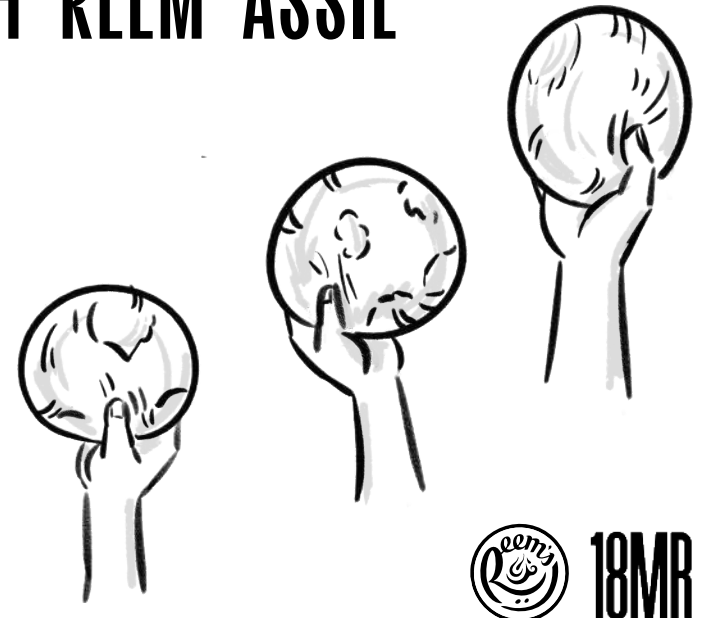
Our Vision: We work within movements for racial justice, abolition, and democracy towards a liberated future for Asian Americans and all marginalized peoples.

Learn more at 18mr.org

ABOUT BRENDA CHI (18MR's Communications Designer)

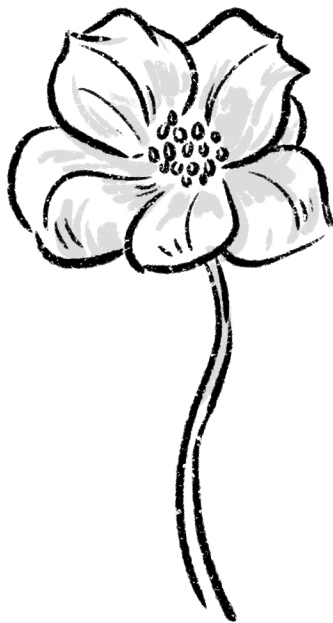
Brenda Chi (she/her) is a queer Chinese-American artist from Los Angeles (Tongva Land), CA. She joined 18MR in 2022 bringing in her decade of experience in entertainment art, apparel, comics and illustration. She hopes to make art that builds community and inspires folks to be part of our fight for liberation.

FOOD IS RESISTANCE: FOR THE LOVE OF BREAD WITH REEM ASSIL



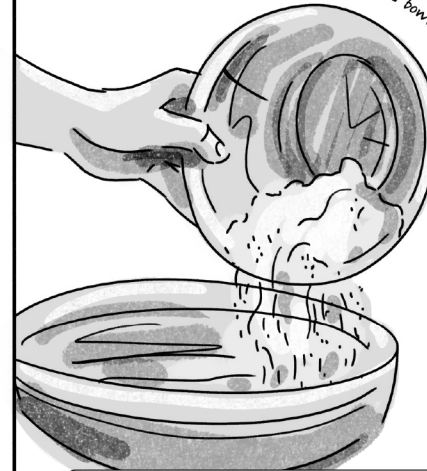
*Written and edited by Reem Assil.
Illustrated and edited by Brenda Chi.*

Thank you Reem, for sharing your story with us.



AS A BAKER,
IT'S PRETTY OBVIOUS
THAT I LOVE BREAD.

*our flour and
water in a bowl*



BUT I DIDN'T START OUT AS A BAKER.

→2001←



IN MY FIRST WEEK OF COLLEGE,
9/11 HAPPENED AND THE ANTI-ARAB
FERVOR GREW RAPIDLY.

I FEARED FOR
THE SAFETY OF ARABS
BOTH IN AMERICA AND
IN OUR HOMELANDS.

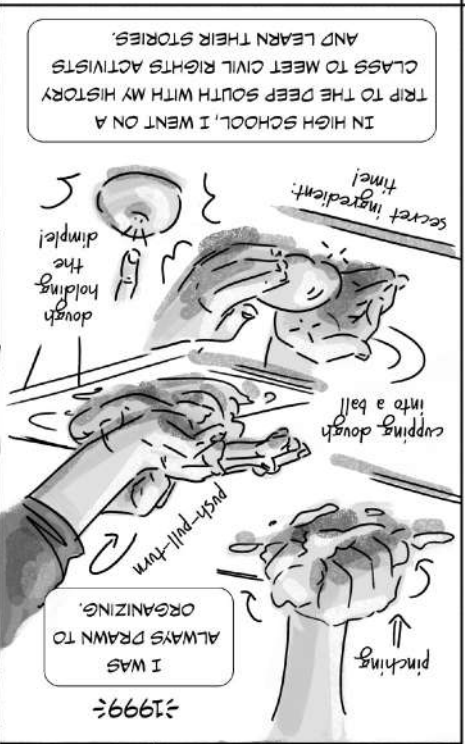
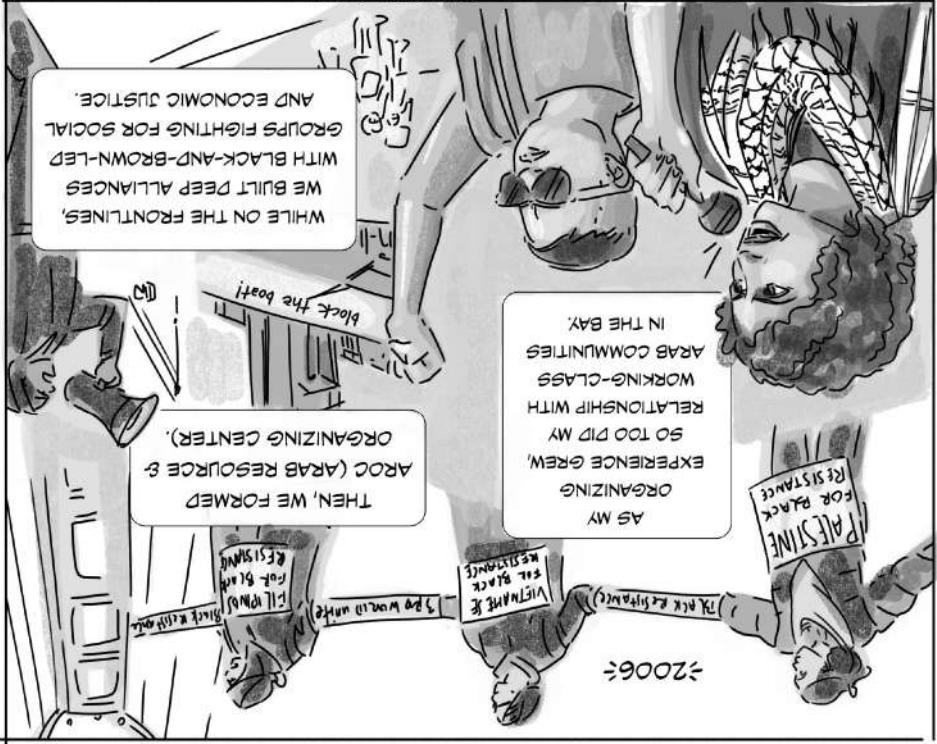


FEELING HELPLESS,
I GREW DEPRESSED
AND DROPPED OUT OF
COLLEGE AND FOUND
MY WAY TO CALIFORNIA.

*mixing to make
that gluten!*



I ENDED UP BUILDING MY OWN
COMMUNITY IN THE BAY AREA OF
ORGANIZERS, CULTURAL WORKERS AND
EDUCATORS CALLING FOR AN END TO
MILITARISM IN OUR COMMUNITIES AND THE
US-LED WAR AND OCCUPATION OF IRAQ.



Divide the prepared risen dough into 10 pieces (about 137 grams each). Shape the pieces into rounds (see page 62), cover with a dry dish towel (or brush the dough with a bit of oil and cover gently with plastic wrap), and let rest for 20 minutes.

Preheat the oven to 550°F. Arrange the oven racks on the upper and lower thirds of the oven; if you are using a baking stone, remove the lower rack from the oven, place the stone on the floor of the oven, and preheat the oven for at least 45 minutes.

Place the dough rounds on a lightly floured work surface, sprinkle them with flour, and pat each round into a 4-inch disk. Working your way around the rim of each disk, use your thumb and index finger to pinch the edges and stretch out the dough. (If the dough is resistant, allow the round to rest, covered with plastic wrap or a dish towel, for another 5 to 10 minutes.) Once you have pinched around the whole circle, sprinkle with a light dusting of flour. Continue the process for the remaining disks.

Using a rolling pin, roll out each round, up and then down once, shift a quarter turn and repeat the process, dusting with flour as needed, until you have an 8-inch disk. Continue the process for the remaining disks. Let the disks rest for another 5 minutes. If space is limited, stagger your disks on top of each other and dust with an ample amount of flour.

Sprinkle a thin layer of flour over two inverted sheet trays and place two or three disks on each one. To give the pita room to rise, remove the top rack of the oven. Place one of the sheet trays on the lower rack for 2 to 3 minutes or until the pita rise into a bubble and you see pleasing spots of brown.

Remove the sheet tray from the oven and transfer the pita in a single layer to a wire rack so they keep their shape. Place your next prepared sheet tray in the oven while your first sheet tray cools. Repeat the process, rotating between the two sheet trays, until all of your pita breads have been baked.

REEM'S ARAB BREAD (KHOBZ ARABI / PITA) RECIPE

From Reem's cookbook *Arabiyya: Recipes from the Life of an Arab in Diaspora* (2022).

5½ cups/770g bread flour
2½ cups/590ml warm water (about 100°F)
1½ teaspoons/6g sugar
1 tablespoon/9g active dry yeast
1 cup/140g all-purpose flour
1 tablespoon/9g kosher salt
¼ cup/60ml extra-virgin olive oil,
plus more for greasing the bowl
Semolina flour for dusting

BASIC YEASTED DOUGH

In the bowl of a stand mixer or in a large bowl, add the bread flour and then stir in 2¼ cups/530ml of the water. With the paddle attachment on low speed or using a sturdy spoon, mix until it resembles a sticky dough. Set aside for 20 minutes. While the flour and water mixture rests, stir together the remaining ¼ Cup/60ml water, sugar, and yeast in a small bowl. Set aside until foamy, about 10 minutes. At this point, the yeast mix should give off a sweet fragrance and show a bubbly bloom.

To mix by hand: Use your hand to incorporate the yeast mixture, all-purpose flour, salt, and oil into the dough. Squeeze the dough between your thumb and fingers with one hand while holding the bowl with the other hand, until it forms a rough and shaggy ball. Turn out the dough onto a lightly floured work surface and knead until the dough is smooth, springs back when dimpled, and stretches like a windowpane. This usually takes up to 10 minutes of kneading.

To mix in a stand mixer: Add the yeast mixture, all-purpose flour, salt, and oil to the bowl and use the dough hook to mix the dough on low speed until everything comes together, scraping the bowl if needed. Turn up the speed to medium and mix until the dough pulls away from the sides of the bowl, 8 to 10 minutes, or until the dough is smooth, springs back when dimpled, and stretches like a windowpane.

Form the dough into a ball. Then coat a large bowl with oil and transfer the dough into the bowl. Cover the bowl with plastic wrap or a damp dish towel and let it rise in a warm draft-free place for 1½ hours or until doubled in size. If you are not planning to use the dough right away, refrigerate for up to 12 hours until doubled in size.



~1993~

AND WAY BEFORE THAT,
I WAS LITTLE REEMO,
LIVING IN BOSTON.



I WAS SPEAKING ARABIC
AT HOME AND CODESWITCHING TO
THE WHITE KIDS AT SCHOOL, WHERE
WE SANG "YANKEE DOODLE DANDY"
AND HAD FIELDTrips TO CELEBRATE
PILGRIMS AT PLYMOUTH ROCK.

ONLY TO LEARN FROM MY UNCLE
EYAD THAT THESE PILGRIMS ALSO
GAVE THE LOCAL TRIBES "SMALL
POX INFECTED BLANKETS" AS AN
ACT OF GERM WARFARE...



...SEEDING AN EARLY
AWARENESS OF SETTLER
COLONIALISM."

~2010~

BUT AFTER YEARS
OF ORGANIZING AND
BURN OUT...

...IT WAS ON A
FAMILY SUMMER
TRIP TO SYRIA AND
LEBANON, THAT I
WAS REBIRTHED...



...THROUGH BREAD.

[SYRIA]

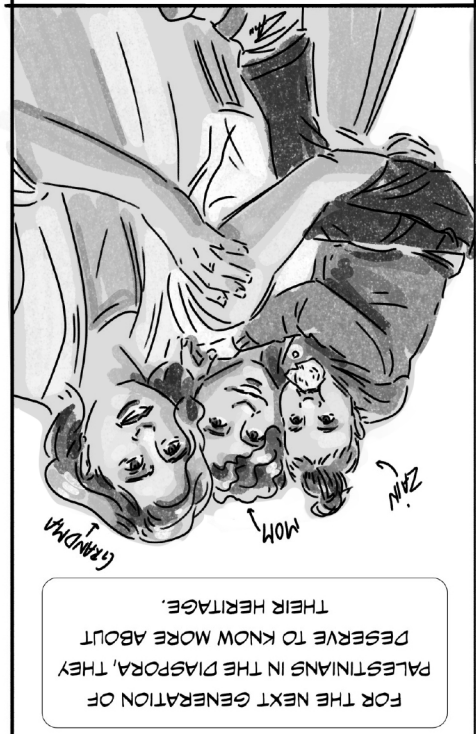
BREAD IS THE
LIFELINE OF MY
PEOPLE AND THE
BAKERY IS KING.



IT STARTED WITH
THE ROADSIDE VENDOR
WHO TENDED A WOOD FIRE
BENEATH THE STEEL DOME
OF HER GRIDDLE...

I STOOD, TRANSFIXED.







AMONG ALL THE BOMBS DROPPING,
GAZANS WERE STILL MAKING BREAD.



WHEN EVERYONE RAN OUT OF GAS,
THE PEOPLE FOUND MATERIALS FROM
THE RUBBLE AND MADE THEIR OWN
FIREWOOD OVENS TO MAKE BREAD.



THE SHARING OF RECIPES
AND PRESERVATION OF
CULTURE THROUGH BEING
ALIVE AND EXISTING IS
RESISTANCE.



WE KEEP
FIGHTING.

THAT WE LEFT PEACEFULLY?!

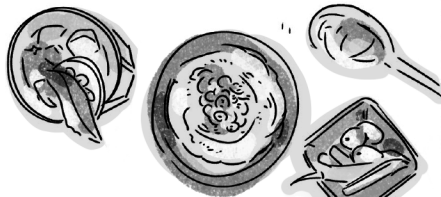


WHAT ARE THEY GOING TO SAY
ABOUT PALESTINIANS?

THEY ALREADY WHITE WASH
INDIGENOUS AND AFRICAN FOOD
WAYS BROUGHT OVER IN THE SLAVE
TRADE CALLING IT "AMERICAN", TO
COVER UP THE TRUTH OF GENOCIDE
AND SETTLER COLONIALISM RIGHT
HERE ON TURTLE ISLAND.



THEY THINK HUMMUS WAS
INVENTED BY ISRAEL, WHEN IT WAS
EATEN BY GENERATIONS OF PEOPLE
ON THAT LAND BEFORE THE
STATE WAS CREATED.



WHAT ARE THEY GOING TO
DO NEXT? WHAT WILL THEY
APPROPRIATE NEXT?

IN 10 YEARS, HOW ARE THEY
GOING TO TALK ABOUT PALESTINIAN
FOOD? ARAB FOOD?

OR WILL THEY
CALL EVERYTHING
ISRAELI?



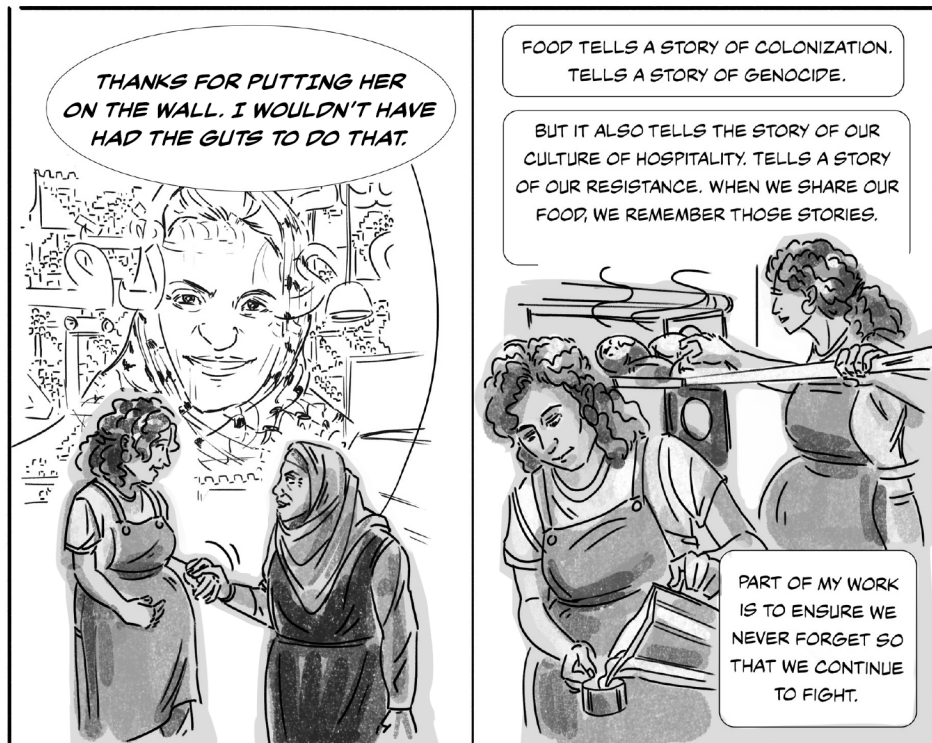
OUR VERY RIGHT TO EXIST IS IN
DANGER BECAUSE OUR LAND IS
BEING STOLEN FROM US.

OUR FOOD IS AN ASSERTION
OF OUR EXISTENCE AND OUR
CONNECTION TO THE LAND.

THE DE-ETHNICIZATION
AND REBRANDING OF MY
PEOPLE'S FOOD AS "ISRAELI" OR
"MEDITERRANEAN" MAKES ME SO
MAP, IT TAKES PALESTINIANS
OUT OF OUR OWN STORY.



FOOD IS ONE OF OUR LAST
FRONTIERS TO UNCOVER THE
TRUTH OF WHAT WE FACED AND
HOW WE STAYED RESILIENT.



FOOD TELLS A STORY OF COLONIZATION.
TELLS A STORY OF GENOCIDE.

BUT IT ALSO TELLS THE STORY OF OUR
CULTURE OF HOSPITALITY. TELLS A STORY
OF OUR RESISTANCE. WHEN WE SHARE OUR
FOOD, WE REMEMBER THOSE STORIES.



THE REMOVAL OF OUR LAND TAKES US AWAY
FROM OUR FOOD, TAKING AWAY OUR HISTORY
AND STORIES. IT'S AN ACT OF GENOCIDE.



[BEIT LAHIA, NORTHERN GAZA]

FROM THE SOUP KITCHENS TO THE
ROOFTOP GARDENS, PALESTINIANS
LIKE MY BELOVED COMRADES YUSEF
ABU RABEA (THAMRA) AND MAHMOUD
ALMADHOUN (GAZA SOUP KITCHEN)
WERE HOLDING DOWN THE NORTH.

"IF WE DON'T
TAKE CARE OF OUR
AGRICULTURAL LAND,
WE WILL LITERALLY
DIE OF HUNGER."
--YUSEF ABU RABEA



...TO BE FREE IS TO BE
CONNECTED TO OUR
ROOTS, NO MATTER THE
CIRCUMSTANCES.



THEY PUT THEIR
LIVES AT RISK TO HELP
FAMILIES GROW THEIR
OWN FOOD AND FEED
THEMSELVES.

THEIR WILL TO DEFY
GENOCIDE MADE THEM TARGETS OF
THE ISRAELI MILITARY. THEY WERE
FREEDOM FIGHTERS. MAY THEY REST
IN ETERNAL PEACE AND FREEDOM AND
THEIR MARTYRDOM BE HONORED AS
WE CONTINUE TO REBUILD GAZA
BETTER THAN IT WAS BEFORE.



MY ORGANIZING FRIENDS AND COMMUNITY WOULD GATHER OVER WARM BREAD, FOOD, AND MANY LAUGHS.

THE CONSTANT BACK AND FORTH BETWEEN GRIEF AND HOPE IS A SOBERING REALITY FOR ALL PALESTINIANS.



I'VE LOST SO MANY FAMILY AND FRIENDS IN GAZA.



A FEW WEEKS AFTER OPENING REEM'S, I WAS HIT WITH ONE OF THE MOST VIOLENT ATTACKS I'D EVER EXPERIENCED.



I FINALLY HAD MY OWN BAKERY IN OAKLAND, CALLED "REEM'S CALIFORNIA". I BECAME THE BAKER IN THE COMMUNITY THAT I DREAMED OF BEING.

OKAY, BACK TO MY STORY.



RIGHT-WING FORCES BEGAN TO PROTEST MY BAKERY ACCUSING ME OF BEING A TERRORIST. ZIONISTS FELT THREATENED BY ANY ASSERTION OF PALESTINIAN PRIDE IN OUR CULTURE AND RESISTANCE AND THEY VOWED TO SILENCE ME.



MY BAKERY HAD A COLORFUL MURAL OF PALESTINIAN MATRIARCH OF THE MOVEMENT, RASMEA ODEH. SHE WAS KNOWN FOR LEADING THE ARAB AMERICAN ACTION NETWORK IN CHICAGO AND BUILDING LEADERSHIP OF HUNDREDS OF DISENFRANCHISED IMMIGRANT ARAB WOMEN. SHE HAD SUFFERED INJUSTICE AND ABUSE AFTER YEARS IN ISRAELI PRISONS AS A YOUNG POLITICAL PRISONER.



BUT RASMEA'S SMILE ON THE WALL REMINDED ME NOT TO BE SCARED AND STAY TRUE TO MY VOICE. SHE HELPED STRENGTHEN MY RESOLVE AND THE RESILIENCE OF SO MANY ARAB WOMEN HERE IN THE US.



MY FAMILY, FRIENDS, AND CUSTOMERS WERE THERE TO PROTECT ME, AND AFTER MY COMMUNITY'S EFFORTS IN RAPID RESPONSE, THE ZIONISTS GAVE UP. THERE WERE TOO MANY OF US!